

Barriers and Facilitators of Specialty Pharmacy Prescription Turnaround Time

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Background & Rationale

- Specialty medication use has grown in recent decades, as has the growth in specialty pharmacies serving patients.
- Prompt treatment initiation is necessary for optimal management of complex conditions.
- Reducing turnaround time (TAT) is crucial for specialty pharmacies to reduce time to treatment initiation and improve patient care.
- Studies demonstrate that best practices can be utilized to reduce turnaround time.
- There is currently limited published information about barriers and facilitators of specialty pharmacy prescription turnaround time.

Objectives

- To determine factors that may influence specialty pharmacy turnaround time.
- To identify best practices that specialty pharmacies utilize to improve turnaround time.

Methods

- Cross-sectional survey conducted, informed by previous focus groups
- Distribution occurred to:
 - National Association of Specialty Pharmacy members
 - Pharmacy Quality Alliance specialty pharmacy members
- Distribution: April-May 2021
- Requested one response per pharmacy location
- Survey question areas included:
 - Barriers and facilitators of turnaround time
 - Perceptions of turnaround time measurement
- Demographic information collected included:
 - Specialty pharmacy type (payer, independent, integrated delivery network, chain, other)
 - Geographic region the pharmacy served
 - Rurality status
 - State in which the pharmacy is located
- Statistical analyses included descriptive statistics of survey responses

Results

Table 1. Survey respondent characteristics (N=54)		
Location	Number of States Represented	23
Specialty Pharmacy Type n (%)	Payer	4 (7%)
	Independent	12 (22%)
	Integrated Delivery Network (IDN)	28 (52%)
	Chain	8 (15%)
	Other	2 (4%)
Urbanicity n (%)	Rural	4 (7%)

Table 2. Top barriers and facilitators to shorter turnaround time		
	Barriers	Facilitators
Prior authorization	72%	6%
Payment assistance program logistics	39%	7%
Electronic prior authorization system	6%	43%
Disease teams within the pharmacy	2%	35%
Physician partnerships	2%	37%
Provider communication	20%	26%
Patient communication	30%	13%
Adequate staffing	20%	20%

Table 3. Top barriers, by specialty pharmacy type				
Barriers	Payer	Independent	IDN	Chain
Benefits investigation	2 (50%)	2 (17%)	6 (21%)	2 (25%)
Prior authorization	3 (75%)	12 (100%)	17 (61%)	6 (75%)
Payment assistance program logistics	2 (50%)	3 (25%)	14 (50%)	1 (13%)
Commercial insurance	0	3 (25%)	4 (14%)	2 (25%)
Provider communication	0	3 (25%)	2 (7%)	5 (63%)
Provider prescribing habits	1 (25%)	3 (25%)	2 (7%)	4 (50%)
Patient communication	1 (25%)	3 (25%)	10 (36%)	2 (25%)

Table 4. Top facilitators, by specialty pharmacy type				
Facilitators	Payer	Independent	IDN	Chain
Benefits investigation	1 (25%)	2 (17%)	1 (4%)	0
Electronic prior authorization system	1 (25%)	4 (33%)	16 (57%)	2 (25%)
Disease teams within the pharmacy	0	5 (42%)	12 (43%)	1 (13%)
Center of Excellence	1 (25%)	0	3 (11%)	0
Physician partnerships	1 (25%)	5 (42%)	12 (43%)	1 (13%)
Provider communication	0	2 (17%)	7 (25%)	4 (50%)
Provider prescribing habits	1 (25%)	1 (8%)	0	2 (25%)
Patient communication	1 (25%)	0	4 (14%)	2 (25%)
Newly diagnosed patient	1 (25%)	0	0	0
Actively managed patient	0	3 (25%)	0	3 (38%)
Formulary changes	1 (25%)	1 (8%)	0	0
Adequate staffing	1 (25%)	2 (17%)	4 (14%)	4 (50%)

Table 5. Respondent opinions and experiences related to SP-TAT				
	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Agree	Strongly Agree
Important for patient satisfaction				X
Important for patient care				X
Ensuring timely access to medications improves patient outcomes			X*	X*
Important to measure SP-TAT** for internal quality improvement				X
Important to measure SP-TAT consistently			X	
SP-TAT is measured consistently across the industry		X		
Need for industry-wide standardization for SP-TAT			X	
Important for performance comparisons in reporting and benchmarking			X	
* Ensuring timely access to medications improves patient outcomes averaged between "Agree" and "Strongly Agree"				
** SP-TAT is Specialty Pharmacy Turnaround Time				

Limitations

- Survey design, while robust, does not capture actual turnaround time.
- Additional research is needed to determine impact of facilitator implementation on turnaround time.

Conclusions

- Respondents indicated that specialty pharmacy turnaround time is inconsistently measured and needs to be standardized.
- Turnaround time measurement was indicated to be important for patient care and satisfaction.
- While prior authorization was consistently cited as a barrier, other barriers and facilitators varied, pointing to the need to align quality improvement initiatives with barriers encountered by the specialty pharmacy.

Specialty pharmacy stakeholders agree on the importance of consistently measuring turnaround time. Barriers and facilitators to shorter turnaround time varied within and across specialty pharmacy types.

References

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